

A SIX-DAY RETREAT IN DAILY LIFE

I Am

Six Days with the “I Am” Sayings of Jesus



DAY ONE The Bread of Life *John 6:32-35*

DAY TWO The Light of the World *John 8:10-12*

DAY THREE The Good Shepherd *John 10:11-15*

DAY FOUR The Resurrection and the Life *John 11:21-27*

DAY FIVE The Way, the Truth and the Life *John 14:1-6*

DAY SIX The True Vine *John 15:1-5*

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IGNATIUS AT HOME

How to Pray These Days



At the burning bush God told Moses his name: I am. In the Gospel of John, Jesus takes that name on his own lips and fills it with the plainest things of daily life: bread, light, a shepherd, a road, a vine. Each saying tells us who he is, and in the same breath who we are to him: the hungry who are fed, the lost who are found, the grieving who are raised, the branches who belong.

For the next six days, spend one time of prayer a day with one of these sayings. About twenty to thirty minutes is enough. Hear Jesus say “I am” to you, not to a crowd, and let each painting help you stay close to him as he speaks.

EACH DAY

- 1. Become still.** Find a quiet place. Sit comfortably, breathe slowly, and become aware that God is already present, looking at you with love.
- 2. Ask for the grace.** Each day names a grace. Ask for it plainly, as something you really want. Desire is where prayer begins.
- 3. Read slowly.** Read the passage aloud if you can, and then read it again. Stay with any word or phrase that holds you; there is no need to finish.
- 4. Enter the scene.** Use the painting and your imagination. Where are you standing? What does Jesus look like as he turns and says “I am” to you?
- 5. Speak as a friend.** End by talking with Jesus in your own words, as one friend speaks to another. Close with the Our Father.
- 6. Notice.** Afterwards, take a moment to notice what stirred: consolation or desolation, peace or resistance. Jot down a word if it helps.

On the last day, or on a seventh day if you can, pray all six sayings slowly together, and notice which of his names has become your own.

THE DAYS

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DAY ONE

The Bread of Life

John 6:32-35



The Last Supper, Juan de Juanes, c. 1562

THE GRACE

Ask for the grace to recognise my deepest hunger, and to come to Jesus to be fed by him rather than by what can never satisfy.

FOCUS

Name what you have been feeding on lately, and watch Jesus lift the bread at the table and hold it out to you.

32 Jesus therefore said to them,

“Most certainly, I tell you, it wasn’t Moses who gave you the bread out of heaven, but my Father gives you the true bread out of heaven.

33 For the bread of God is that which comes down out of heaven, and gives life to the world.”

34 They said therefore to him, “Lord, always give us this bread.”

35 Jesus said to them,

“I am the bread of life. He who comes to me will not be hungry, and he who believes in me will never be thirsty.

DAY TWO

The Light of the World

John 8:10-12



The Light of the World, William Holman Hunt, 1851–1853

THE GRACE

Ask for the grace to step out of hiding into the light of Jesus, and to know that his light shows me the way without condemning me.

FOCUS

Hear Jesus knocking at the overgrown door of your heart, lantern in hand, and notice what it would take to open it.

¹⁰ Jesus, standing up, saw her and said,
“Woman, where are your accusers? Did no one condemn you?”

¹¹ She said, “No one, Lord.”
Jesus said,
“Neither do I condemn you. Go your way. From now on, sin no more.”

¹² Again, therefore, Jesus spoke to them, saying,
“I am the light of the world.
He who follows me will not walk in the darkness, but will have the light of life.”

DAY THREE

The Good Shepherd

John 10:11-15



The Good Shepherd, Bernhard Plockhorst, late 19th century

THE GRACE

Ask for the grace to know that I am known by name and carried, and that Jesus has laid down his life for me.

FOCUS

Let yourself be the lamb in the Shepherd's arms, and notice where you have been trusting hired hands instead of him.

11 I am the good shepherd.

The good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep.

12 He who is a hired hand, and not a shepherd, who doesn't own the sheep, sees the wolf coming, leaves the sheep, and flees. The wolf snatches the sheep, and scatters them.

13 The hired hand flees because he is a hired hand, and doesn't care for the sheep.

14 I am the good shepherd. I know my own, and I'm known by my own;

15 even as the Father knows me, and I know the Father. I lay down my life for the sheep.

DAY FOUR

The Resurrection and the Life

John 11:21-27



The Raising of Lazarus, Sebastiano del Piombo, 1517–1519

THE GRACE

Ask for the grace to bring Jesus my grief and disappointment as honestly as Martha did, and to answer him with her “Yes, Lord.”

FOCUS

Tell Jesus where you wish he had come sooner, and then listen as he asks you, “Do you believe this?”

21 Therefore Martha said to Jesus, “Lord, if you would have been here, my brother wouldn’t have died.

22 Even now I know that, whatever you ask of God, God will give you.”

23 Jesus said to her,
“Your brother will rise again.”

24 Martha said to him, “I know that he will rise again in the resurrection at the last day.”

25 Jesus said to her,
“I am the resurrection and the life. He who believes in me will still live, even if he dies.

26 Whoever lives and believes in me will never die. Do you believe this?”

27 She said to him, “Yes, Lord. I have come to believe that you are the Christ, God’s Son, he who comes into the world.”

DAY FIVE

The Way, the Truth and the Life

John 14:1-6



Christ Pantocrator, Unknown Byzantine icon painter, 6th century

THE GRACE

Ask for the grace of an untroubled heart, trusting that Jesus himself is the way even when, like Thomas, I cannot see where I am going.

FOCUS

Look into the face of Christ in the icon, and ask him to be your way through the road that troubles you most right now.

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- ¹ “Don’t let your heart be troubled. Believe in God. Believe also in me.
 - ² In my Father’s house are many homes. If it weren’t so, I would have told you. I am going to prepare a place for you.
 - ³ If I go and prepare a place for you, I will come again, and will receive you to myself; that where I am, you may be there also.
 - ⁴ Where I go, you know, and you know the way.”
 - ⁵ Thomas said to him, “Lord, we don’t know where you are going. How can we know the way?”
 - ⁶ Jesus said to him,
“I am the way, the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father, except through me.

DAY SIX

The True Vine

John 15:1-5



The Red Vineyard, Vincent van Gogh, 1888

THE GRACE

Ask for the grace to remain in Jesus as a branch remains in the vine, and to trust the Father's hand even when he prunes.

FOCUS

Notice where you are straining to bear fruit by yourself, and simply rest in him, like the vineyard in the evening sun.

¹ “I am the true vine, and my Father is the farmer. ² Every branch in me that doesn’t bear fruit, he takes away. Every branch that bears fruit, he prunes, that it may bear more fruit. ³ You are already pruned clean because of the word which I have spoken to you. ⁴ Remain in me, and I in you. As the branch can’t bear fruit by itself, unless it remains in the vine, so neither can you, unless you remain in me. ⁵ I am the vine. You are the branches. He who remains in me, and I in him, the same bears much fruit, for apart from me you can do nothing.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

Credits



SCRIPTURE

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PAINTINGS

DAY ONE

Juan de Juanes (c. 1507–1579), *The Last Supper*, c. 1562. Museo del Prado, Madrid. Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

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William Holman Hunt (1827–1910), *The Light of the World*, 1851–1853. Keble College, Oxford. Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

DAY THREE

Bernhard Plockhorst (1825–1907), *The Good Shepherd*, late 19th century. Original location unknown; widely reproduced as a print. Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

DAY FOUR

Sebastiano del Piombo (c. 1485–1547), *The Raising of Lazarus*, 1517–1519. National Gallery, London. Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

DAY FIVE

Unknown Byzantine icon painter, *Christ Pantocrator*, 6th century. Saint Catherine’s Monastery, Sinai. Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

DAY SIX

Vincent van Gogh (1853–1890), *The Red Vineyard*, 1888. Pushkin State Museum of Fine Arts, Moscow. Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

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